

QUESTIONS OF PRACTICE: THE 2004 SOUTH CAROLINA SENATE DEBATES

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Even the most cursory glance at the scholarly work on electoral debates and political argument over the past twenty years might lead an observer unfamiliar with the American political system to think that we hold elections only once every four years, and for only one position: the president. For whatever reason, the bulk of work produced on the topic of modern electoral debates in America, particularly the televised ones, has relied heavily on a presidential-centric focus. Beginning with the 1960 Kennedy/Nixon race and moving forward throughout the past five decades, the year following a presidential campaign witnesses a boom of journal articles, book chapters, and conference reports analyzing and critiquing whatever presidential debates were held that year. Sometimes this scholarly attention includes primary debates. In other instances vice presidential candidates are drawn into the mix. Yet rarely has anything at the state or local level been explored in any systematic fashion.

Perhaps this narrowly tailored function is a product of convenience, emerging from a need to establish common reference points for broader discussion of argument and debate, a need that is satisfied by the high-profile commonality of a national presidential race. This may be especially true among those argumentation and debate scholars whose central research focus is more centered on the architecture and the nuances of messaging, and less on the particular issues of individual campaigns.¹ In such situations, the high visibility of the

¹ Of course, the assumption is that somehow the presidential race does create a stable or static body of common national issues, rhetorical moments, themes, etc. that enable scholars from varied geographies to have productive conversations on such matters. This sense of stability may be illusionary given the polysemic nature of such elements. However, the perception of such commonality is what is important here.

presidential race provides just enough familiarity on issues to make discussion possible. We might even argue that the field itself is still rather young, and this focus is a natural result of building a base of analysis.¹ Yet, convenience and commonality do not necessarily lead to productive outcomes, and we tread on shaky ground if we presuppose that the extraordinary and the occasional can easily be applied with little translation to the everyday and local. While this is not meant to imply that such president-centered studies are somehow counterproductive, the concern still exists that an overly intensive focus on these particular races to the exclusion of state and local ones presents an occluded picture of everyday electoral debate as it exists in the mythical spaces of the supposed “off year” and among those people we may call the “down balloters.”

I do not mean to suggest that there is a complete absence of such works in the literature. Scattered across different publications, a handful of scholars from a variety of methodological backgrounds have turned their focus to include a wider variety of political debate formats in their work.² On a positive note, new communication technologies are making it easier to remotely access, and hopefully critically examine, “down-ballot” debates across the country that were previously out of reach for the average researcher. In addition, the growing body of English language work dealing with political oriented debates in other countries has, for obvious reasons, expanded the range of offices under examination.³ However, even with this spotty improvement, the overwhelming majority of works in the area continue to rely on presidential campaigns as a focal point for

¹ By the term “young” I mean to suggest that the analysis of televised electoral debates is a product of the last 50 years. It is only natural, therefore, that scholars turned their attention to the high-profile events such as presidential debates. Yet such a focus if left unchallenged stifles the growth of the field to the extent that these races are periodic and only able to provide new case studies (in most instances, at least) once every four years.

² For instance, Seiter (2003) utilizes a mock televised student government debate, Jarvis and Connaughton (2005) focus their attention on Texas gubernatorial debates, and Arnie and Benoit (2005) examine the 2004 Illinois Senate debates.

³ For brief examples of work that examines televised debates in a non-American context see Jorgensen, Kock & Rorbech’s (1998) work on issue debates in Denmark, as well as Schrott’s (1990) examination of West German party debates. However, in some instances, comparative examinations

examination.¹ In this sense, the time is long overdue for those of us interested in such work to begin to refocus our efforts on other electoral candidate debates, including statewide and local races.

The National vs. the State and Local: Meeting Theory and Practice

A forum such as this one that seeks to refocus our attention on the importance of these argumentative moments as object of analysis is the right medicine at the right time. Yet, it is not simply a question of artifacts for analysis. While the imbalance as it pertains to reflective scholarship and the focus of published studies is quite clear and in need of adjustment, the parallel areas of service and community engagement appear quite murky. Though no formal study I know of has even attempted to comprehensively track such activities, from my own experience it appears that many of us who spend our days examining political debates also spend our evenings organizing and participating in such debates. Whether as producers, moderators, campaign advisors, or “color commentators,” argument and debate scholars manage to get involved in the practical planning elements of making debates happen in their community and, in particular, on their local campus. Some of these debates do involve candidates seeking electoral office. While many of us dream (or have nightmares) of the day we might host a presidential debate on our campus, it is far more likely than in any given electoral cycle our efforts are largely targeted at state and local races. For those that are not engaged in such activities, I might suggest that they are missing a great opportunity to provide a service to the community, enhance the stature of their department and/or institution, provide opportunities for direct student engagement, and open

still utilize American presidential debates as a counterpoint to their non-American manifestations; see Mueller (2005) for instance.

¹ Recent examples of work dealing with the U.S. presidential debates include Jarman’s (2005) audience effects analysis of the 2004 debates, Ben-Porath’s (2005) analysis of the role questioning played in the 2004 New Hampshire primary debate, Doerfel and Connaughton’s (2005) longitudinal analysis of presidential debates since 1960, Herbeck and Mehlretter’s (2005) examination of memory and the first Nixon Kennedy debate, Daily, Hinck and Hinck’s (2005) examination of politeness in both the 2000 and 2004 presidential races, and Morello’s (2005) analysis of the 2004 town hall style presidential debate.

a space to practically apply what are often hypothetical discussions regarding the formats of such debates.

It is therefore oddly ironic that we publish accounts that tend to over-emphasize the salience of presidential debates, while at the same time we more often find ourselves organizing “down ballot” debates for state and local electoral office in our respective communities.¹ In the end, this gap between community activities (the state and local) and object of study (the national) subtly impedes an organized conversation about how to vibrantly improve the former and, at the same time, diversify the corpus of the latter. We rarely write about our experiences putting on these local debates, and as a result there is less of the coordination, planning, and sharing of individual examples that would help improve public debate. At the same time, the very case studies we do write about (particularly when we criticize an element of format) address the types of debates that most of us will never be directly involved in planning. While it is true that research on presidential debates may sometimes inform our decisions when putting on local debates, there are significant differences. Therefore, the issue of focus is also a question of practice, and any solution to the current situation lies not only in increasing the scope of our analysis outright, but also in the reconnection between the theoretical object and the practically active “scholar” as subject.²

It is my hope that in considering ways to rebalance our focus, we take up this dialogue of practice. At a most basic level there would be the tangible benefit in terms of improving our efforts to stage such electoral driven debates on our campuses. At the same time, it might just help facilitate the type of collaborative information sharing that will make

¹ I personally have been guilty of such an odd twist of priorities. During the course of the 2004 campaign, I worked in some capacity on producing a number of different state and local debates. Yet, at the National Communication Association convention that year, I gave a presentation on the presidential debates.

² While this claim may raise all kinds of unrelated complications, I would at the very least argue that a certain reluctance to treat as object of analysis what we as individuals act to create (in this instance an examination of a debate I also worked to produce) could contribute to the presidential-centric focus of our work. From an interpretive perspective, the very debates at the local level that one might know well enough to write about also happen to be the same debates you help organize and plan.

possible a wider scope for our theoretical work. In an effort to spark a dialogue on issues that go into planning these types of events, the rest of this piece will be directed at a handful of debate planning concerns rooted in my own anecdotal experiences producing state and local electoral debates in the 2004 election. I am certain that nearly all the issues addressed are ones that debate planners have dealt with on many occasions, though in an ad hoc fashion. To think that my own experiences from one particular year (or that any one set of experiences from any year) could be instructional for the wide, diverse array of contexts from which such debates emerge would be foolish. It is not my intent to provide one set of recommendations for how to host a state or local televised debate. Certainly in the short term I would hope this account would raise some questions and provide some new ideas for those planning such debates in the future. In a broader sense, this account will hopefully spark a larger dialogue by highlighting some issues of practice that are not always visible in our current literature, yet which themselves merit debate and discussion.

The 2004 College of Charleston Senate Debate

The jumping off point for this piece is our experience in producing a series of debates (most notably a statewide televised US Senate debate) on the campus of the College of Charleston (CofC) in Charleston, South Carolina.¹ The 2004 campaigns offered a comparative moment to examine first hand the differences in tone and texture between hosting presidential versus state and local debate events on campus. During the long presidential primary season, we were fortunate enough to receive a heavy dose of attention from the Democrats seeking their party's nomination. Due to both the timing of its primary within the Democratic Party calendar, as well as the particular conditions of the campaign that year, South Carolina was a site of intense electoral activities for several months in advance of the 2004 primary. As one of only a handful of sizable Democratic pockets in the

¹ The author served as a visiting faculty member in the Department of Communication at the College of Charleston during the 2004 election cycle.

state, the Charleston metropolitan area was targeted with sustained canvassing and GOTV efforts.

The CofC campus itself hosted a number of speaking engagements, debates, and issue forums for the Democratic nominees, including public events with Howard Dean, John Edwards, John Kerry, Al Sharpton, Carol Moseley Braun, Wes Clark, and their surrogates. In the weeks leading up to the primary, national and international media descended on Charleston and other major South Carolina cities looking to cover candidates on the stump and take the “temperature” of South Carolina primary voters. For us, this fervor culminated in a political carnival-like atmosphere as the now defunct CNN program “Inside Politics” arrived in their ceremonial campaign buses and staged a live broadcast from the heart of campus days before the primary. Like political moths to an earned media flame, campaign advance staff rushed to set up staged events with candidates, family members of candidates, volunteers, celebrities, and musicians. All of these public communication events, no matter how chaotic or absurdist, opened up great opportunities for our students to observe the “behind the scenes” preparation that goes into staging a forum or debate. This was a great coup for those taking our political communication classes. For many of our less politically active students, the demystification of the political image that results from such first hand observation helped foment a sharper critical perspective both in the classroom and in their own public activities.

In the wake of the presidential primary, the summer and fall also brought with it numerous debate and speaking events on campus that were tied to the 2004 general election. Given the supposed “no play” status of the state for the Presidential race, these public events were primarily centered on state and local electoral candidates and elections. We had the great fortune of working with students, other faculty, and third party nonpartisan organizations (such as the League of Women voters and South Carolina Educational Television) to schedule debates and issue forums both on and off campus. The most visible of all these was a statewide-televised debate held on campus in early October between the two candidates vying for the recently vacated U.S. Senate seat from South Carolina. This

seat had long been held by Democrat Fritz Hollings and was “open” for the first time since 1966. Given the vast partisan turnaround in the southern politics over this period, and the growing Republican dominance of statewide offices, the South Carolina Democrats were desperate to retain what was, at the time, their highest profile office.

Following a tough primary season, upstate Congressperson Jim DeMint won the Republican nomination and was seen, if for this reason alone, to be the political favorite. His opponent was one of only two Democrats currently holding statewide office (not including the retiring Hollings): Education Superintendent Inez Tenenbaum. While Tenenbaum was considered one of the most prominent and experienced Democrats in the state, the specter of any South Carolina Democrat having to run for statewide office in a presidential year where the top of the ticket diverges from the ideological leanings of the statewide base creates serious messaging constraints. These messaging complications combined with a severe monetary gap and South Carolina’s apparent tendency to elect very few women to public office left most observers believing that Tenenbaum would have to run a flawless campaign to win the seat.¹

The impetus for the college to host an on-campus debate slowly developed through conversations between me and the news director at the local CBS affiliate WCSC. As soon as the primaries were over, we began in earnest crafting a plan to secure a televised debate between DeMint and Tenenbaum to be held on campus. This included contacting other third party organizations to find out if they were already planning to schedule their own series of debates. Bridging this “territorial” issue was vitally important both to avoid conflicts and to enhance our legitimacy when we took the final proposal to the candidates. At the same

¹ While we might dispute the origins of the state’s political gender gap, it is virtually impossible to argue that one does not exist. Prior to the most recent election, the actual number of women who served in the South Carolina state legislature has plummeted over the past decade to the point that South Carolina has ranked last in the nation for the past four years in terms of percentage of women elected to political office. Prior to Tenenbaum, only two women had ever been elected to statewide office: one was Tenenbaum’s predecessor at the Department of Education, the second, a one term Lt. Governor in the early 1980s. Of the five South Carolina women who have ever been elected to Congress, four of them won the office in special elections only after the death of their husbands who were currently holding the office.

time, we secured logistical and technical details on campus as well as an informal partnership agreement with South Carolina Public Television (SCETV) for statewide broadcast. The WCSC news manager and I worked to craft a debate format and go over the basics of how we saw the debate and its role as the first televised event of the campaign season. It was only then, after we had flushed out the basic participant format and themes that we drafted an invitation letter and formally contacted the campaigns. While there had been some informal personal overtures to find out dates and other assorted items, we held back formally contacting the campaigns with an invitation until we had completed the planning.

After a few hiccups, we were able to finally solidify the deal and get both campaigns on board. We had made sure to plan a press rollout the next day (starting with WCSC of course) in order to maximize the media coverage for the event. Most of this planning had occurred in the late summer and, as a result, we had weeks to prepare the specific details once the agreement was formalized. In the weeks leading up the event, we hammered out a second wave of last minute details, helped prepare the moderator, and organized a diverse audience to be present at the event. In the end, the debate was held in one of the most prominent and identifiable spaces on campus, and was broadcast live over statewide public television, public radio, and WCSC. The event was formally a partnership between the College, WCSC, SCETV, and the League of Women Voters. The League provided their endorsement and also helped provide some volunteers to deal with the audience on the day of the event. WCSC provided the bulk of the technical production elements and one of their young “talents” to be the moderator. SCETV agreed to pick up the feed from the WCSC truck and broadcast it live over statewide public television and radio. Our team here at the college handled all the logistical issues including the venue, technical support for our facilities, and debate preparation for the moderator.

In the end, the debate itself went off without a hitch, and attracted a great deal of attention in the state and national press because of both its timing (as the first major debate between the candidates) and because of some of the issues that came up during the debate.

Our students seemed to benefit from the experience, and the department as well as the College was positive about the attention it garnered throughout the state. At the same time, many of choices we made along the way could have easily gone in a different direction, thereby leading to completely different outcomes (some better some worse). Yet many of these choices seem so natural as to be nearly automatic. I would hope that a discussion of individual case studies such as this would provoke our community to re-examine these assumptions about debates that we have frequently taken as a given. Based on our experiences, I would suggest that anyone planning to host a similar on-campus, candidate-driven debate should at least pause for a moment when addressing the following questions.

How Do We Secure the Debate?

Like it or not, high profile statewide races will tend to resemble presidential elections when it comes to the political complexities of working with campaigns to hammer out the details of the event. Initially it may be more difficult to agree to get these candidates to appear at the debate. Frankly, no matter how much we would like to think otherwise, candidates for these offices typically are not agreeing to debates out of their inherent respect for the value of public discourse. In more instances the debate is seen as a strategically important moment, fraught with danger and unpredictability at a time when campaigns staff place a premium on controlled messaging environments. Not only does the host have to convince the candidates that the debate will be executed professionally, but the campaign has to believe that the debate is in their best interest, or that, alternatively, it is against their best interest to refuse to attend. Depending on the dynamics of the particular race, and the public communication skills of the candidates, certain campaigns will do as much as possible to limit the number of debates and to control the environment in order to minimize unpredictability. Some challengers might want just the opposite: as many debates as possible and under very open-ended conditions. At the same time, while having to make sure the campaigns are on board with the event, your planning team may well be competing with other groups rushing to stage debates and put together their own proposals.

Candidates for local office are usually more enthusiastic about attending forums and debate events. Though there will still be those who, because of the dynamics of their particular race, or simply because of scheduling, will not participate in a local forum or debate, our experience has been that the vast majority of those candidates are eager to be involved and, at the same time, make fewer demands on the organizers in terms of format. They are often eager for any attempt at earned media, they place a higher premium on community and civic group sponsored voter contact (especially in the most local of races), they see such events as tests to show their own viability, and since not everyone is clamoring to host these debates, they have little to go by in terms of making demands on organizers. On the other hand, campaigns for more high profile offices such as Senate and Governor are more likely to go back and forth about when, where, and how many debates there will be during the cycle. In addition, these campaigns will be more interested in negotiating the details of the debate down to the fine line.

With all of this in mind, I believe that “securing” may be the best term used to describe pinning down all the loose ends and making sure the debate gets off the ground. In some races there may be only a handful of debates agreed from the outset. In these instances, the host should recognize that there is both a premium on time and also on adequate planning. Your goal is to quickly establish your debate’s perceived “legitimacy” compared to other options. Of course all of our debates are legitimate, but if it is true that campaigns choose to do debates in a cost-benefit strategic framework, then it is important to demonstrate that your proposal is the most desirable given the specifics of that race. Campaigns need to be convinced that if they are only going to do “x” number of joint events, your debate has to be one of them.

This legitimization process entails several elements. First, it is crucial that your team comes up with a very well planned reason why your debate is “special.” Realistically speaking, if you want the campaigns to pick your debate from other possible competing options, you need to have a “hook.” I don’t mean to imply the use of cheap gimmicks, or that this “hook” should even be the primary selling point. However, as a subtle reminder,

those working to plan the campaign should always have in the back of their minds this basic question: why is this debate significant enough that candidates should consider it above others? If your debate is on campus you may also want to ask yourself what about the college setting is tied to the debate content itself. This issue will be explored in more detail in the next section.

For us it was combination of elements that helped us answer the question of why they were “special.” This would be the first debate to kick off the season and it would ostensibly be the only one to take place in the “low country.” In terms of electoral strategy, the low country of South Carolina is a balanced swing area of the state that was Hollings’s home base. Yet, neither DeMint nor Tenenbaum came from the area or lived there for any lengthy period of time. In addition to its broadcast on SCETV, the debate would also be carried live at 7:00 p.m. on local CBS affiliate WCSC that, at the time, held the largest share of the Lowcountry viewing audience. For us, we “spun” the debate as an opportunity for the candidates to kick off the campaign by introducing themselves to low country voters and make the case for being the successor to Hollings. At the same time, the debate would take place on the CofC campus in the historic Alumni Hall, a place which had seen many significant debates and orations conducted for over two centuries. The packaging of these together worked out well, and provided us with a strong selling point, subtly slipped into conversations.

Second, in order to foster the perception of legitimacy, we promoted prior positive experiences in collaborative ventures with third-party organizations. Often times there are nonpartisan civic organizations in the community who may give a stamp of approval to the debate. They may consider themselves co-sponsors if only in name. Cooperating with these groups should not be seen as a dilution of your role in the process, but as a way to help synergize common interests. In our instance, long before we took our proposal to the campaigns we contacted the League of Women Voters (who we already had an ongoing relationship with) and asked them to endorse the event. They agreed, and this ended up

boosting the legitimacy of our debate both by having their name on the event and by precluding them from hosting similar events in the area.

Third, one of the most important elements of legitimating your debate(s) in the eyes of the campaigns is professionalism. The worst thing I would argue that you could do is approach one candidate or campaign and simply say “Hey we would like to do a debate.” In approaching the campaigns about the debate they need to believe that your team can act as honest, good faith brokers who will not try to rig the debate for or against one candidate. At the same time, they need to believe that you are experienced in hosting such events, and that the debate will go off professionally. Those of us in the debate and argumentation community have a lot to offer in this regard. As observers of historical and contemporary debate, our inclusion on the planning team can offer, whether legitimate or not, the sense that there is a great deal of background knowledge on the part of the hosts. In our instance, our initial core team was adamant about planning everything before going to the campaigns in any official capacity. This meant securing a commitment on venue, statewide broadcast, and endorsement ahead of time. It also meant sitting down and planning out the basic contours of the debate including the format, setting, and the major actors.

Yet, the level of detail you provide to campaigns early on is a tricky situation. In the invitation letter, you will certainly want to provide all the major high points for the debate so that they feel secure in their agreement. However, an overemphasis on the minute details in the initial invitation may bog down the discussion and stall agreement. So the tricky part is crafting an invitation that demonstrates how well planned the event will be, lays out the basic contours for the event, and yet does not invite a debate over formatting details. At the same time, you never want the invitation so be so vague as to open a space for candidates to claim the debate was not what they had agreed upon. Based on our varied experience, this initial letter should include: the date of the debate (with a backup possibility or possibilities in case of conflict), the place of the debate (and be specific), the general format of the debate, the moderator or compositions of panelists in the debate (I generally like a specific moderator ahead of time in the initial letter, though panelists can be represented as certain

typologies such as a “college professor,” “student representative,” “media representative,” or “uncommitted voter”), how the debate will be viewed (local audience as well as any televised or radio coverage), and who will be sponsoring the event. You may also want to include a deadline for response if you feel it necessary. Once the candidates have officially agreed to participate in the debate, the hosts can then quickly secure earned media announcing the debate. Typically this involves drafting a release which is signed off on by the sponsors and shown to the campaigns in advance. The more the local and statewide media report on the debate being agreed upon, the less easy it will be for participants to later back out.

Once the debate is agreed to, the hosts should draft a more technical document outlining the “rules” for the debate. The more high profile the campaign, the more likely you will need more “rules” (at least from the perspective of the candidates). In reality I think you are always in a better position if you don’t see these as rules at all, but instead guidelines for how the debate will proceed. This includes specific details about the format such as questioning style, numbers of speeches, how candidates will be addressed, order of turns, chances for rebuttal, and whether or not the candidates can directly question each other. This document should also include a minimal description of the setting such as: what the seating will look like and where the candidates will be relative to each other, what lighting will be used, what will be the composition of the audience (assuming one exists), how many supporters the candidate can have in the audience, what will be on the table (water, pen, papers) and what the candidate can bring to the debate (notes, props, flasks, etc.).

There are also a series of optional logistical planning issues you may want to consider including, and at the very least should resolve prior to the debate such as: if there will be separate rooms for candidates to prepare and for campaign staff and family to watch the debate (highly recommended), how access with the media gathered for the event will be managed, will there be rallies allowed before or after the event on campus, how close to the event will these be allowed, will candidate be able to show commercials immediately

following the debate, etc.. In our debate at CofC we set up two private rooms where the candidates could prepare in advance. We stocked the room with snacks and assigned student liaisons to let us know if there were problems. The family and staff of the candidates could then remain in the rooms to watch the debate through live simulcast we had set up. In addition, the candidates could go back to the room after the debate for a moment to relax before meeting with guests and the media. We sequestered the media in a third room during the debate (also equipped with simulcast of the debate). This way they could work to make deadlines as the debate progressed without disrupting the debate itself. We did not allow the campaign teams access to the media during the debate for obvious reasons. We then brought the candidates back to the media room on an individual basis to meet with the media for one on one interviews. These are some of the nuts and bolts that you may not need to include in your technical document, but that you need to give serious consideration to prior to the event.

One comprehensive document should outline all that is listed here. This document can be sent to the campaigns (assuming they haven't already requested it) about four weeks before the debate. This will enable them to request considerations of revisions, modify their practice schedule, etc.. From my experience one revision often opens the floodgates to a cycle of back and forth adjustments. While these may be necessary depending on the campaigns (you don't want to call off a debate over format) hosts should work hard to smooth over any concerns and at the same time prevent micro-editing of all the guidelines. I would also strongly advise against "signed" documents (especially at this point in the process). Often I have found groups who ask the candidates to sign these format documents to show their agreement. These signatures are meaningless legally, difficult to explain in the media in event of cancellation, and more likely than not, they are going to encourage a more critical reading of the guidelines by the campaign staff than if you had just sent it out no signature required. In the end, all of these issues offer points for discussion, research, and future collaboration. At the very least, a dialogue on these "nuts and bolts" issues should

help others begin to set up electoral debates as well enhance the quality of the proposals many of us send out to candidates already.

What is the Role for Students?

One of the most complex yet often unexpected questions that confront campus debate organizers is the role of students (particularly undergraduates) in the process. While the pedagogical goal of providing an enriching and hands-on experience for our students is always in the forefront, there are a wide variety of ways this can be accomplished and an equally wide variety of challenges that may not seem obvious at first. Our experience in the 2004 debates anecdotally suggests that state and local elections offer a broader array of avenues for direct student involvement (at least with regard to executing on-campus debates) than do the larger national campaigns such as you find with a presidential election. Though any debate held on campus offers a good chance for students to engage the process if only by direct observation behind the scenes, a broader critical discussion within our community can help generate new ideas for how to uniquely maximize this engagement and tailor it to the needs of the particular public event.

It should be clear that the question of student involvement in this element of electoral public debate has rarely manifested itself in our scholarship. While our community has, with good reason, spent a good deal of effort in bringing debate as an activity to all forms of diverse student audiences, and while we have worked to empower students to host issue debates and forums on campus, the issue of giving students an experience in hosting electoral debates at the state level is a different matter. This is not to suggest that we don't already do it in practice, but simply that there doesn't appear to be any broad systemic effort to coordinate and learn from these sorts of activities. For the most part, we don't hold conference panels, produce journal articles, create collections, or gather data on the specific topic of engaging students in electoral debate production. It is true, however, that those in other disciplinary areas who concern themselves with avenues for direct student engagement specifically in than electoral context have written volumes on the general topic of student

engagement, both from a theoretical and practically applied standpoint. Perhaps this difference can be attributed to the fact that we are dealing with a much smaller field, or perhaps the idea of encouraging direct action through electoral channels has become passé in the fields of rhetoric and communication. For some at least, the gap between some ideal of issue driven debate and what actually occurs at the electoral level may have become so wide as to encourage a shift to non-electoral debates.

Our experience in 2004 demonstrates that one of the most important determining factors in the level of student engagement with the debate event is how the debate is envisioned thematically. At its core this comes down to “why” the college or student organization is sponsoring the debate in the first place. It is only natural that as a community of interested debate and argument scholars we would jump in headfirst often without considering this core issue. Many of us want to be directly involved in some capacity in order to augment the quality of the discourse and to bring events to our local campuses. However, as previously noted, both for pedagogical reasons and for your ability to “sell” the idea to the campaigns, the debate host should have a very specific idea of the relationship between the college and the debate itself. Why is it being held on your campus? The answer is often directly tied to the issue of student engagement. For some, the answer will come first and determine the outcome of the student engagement question. For others, the opposite is true: the identity of the debate and its relation to the institution will flow from the needs of the students.

On the more minimal end of the spectrum, the “reasoning” for hosting the debate on campus may have more to do with availability of a large public space, and thus the college campus as “place” fades to the background. The campus literally acts only as a “site” for debate, and the role of students is often limited to appearing as an audience. Certainly there will be some students who help plan the event, but for the most part, the role of undergraduates will be confined to making up the physically present immediate audience. In other instances, however, the caricature of the ideal “student” becomes the initially constructed imaginary audience that gives the campus debate its unique tone. Put more

simply, under this second model there is an assumption that a campus debate should address supposed student issues, solicit student questions, and open a space for students as imagined audience to actively make their concerns known to political figures.¹ In these instances, the idea of a debate on campus implies a debate that addresses student concerns for a substantial portion of the event (though not exclusively). Thus there is a more direct connection between site and format than in the more minimal model of a simply student audience.

While these two loose groupings can account for a lot of state and local campus debates, alternative ways of envisioning the relationship of the event to the institutional mission present new avenues for undergraduate engagement. In the instance of the Senate debate at CofC, we went in the exact opposite direction of both models. As previously noted, instead of linking the site with “student issues,” we rooted the significance of on campus “place” in a different context. As such, at no point in the debate did the moderator choose to address student issues in any prioritized way, reference the college as site to preface a question, or solicit questions from students in the audience. Further, the small audience for the debate contained a diverse mix of students, community leaders, political supporters, faculty, and staff.

At first this may seem to be the least student centered of the formats, it actually offered new and diverse ways for our students to involve themselves in the planning and

¹ I use the term “supposed” here for very specific reasons. While based solely on anecdotal experience, it is often the case that non-students involved in the planning of this type of debate (campaign management staff, journalists, college administration, etc.) often presuppose on behalf of students a series of issue concerns that are far off base. Relying heavily on a calculation of rational self-interest, these planners wrongly assume that certain issues such as funding and administration of student loan programs, or the job creation policies of current officials, will consistently spark student interest and reflect “their” concerns. This view can infect the entire process from candidate messaging to question choices, to the filtering and prioritizing of student-submitted questions. On the other hand, there may be those willing to defend, in varying degrees, a stewardship approach, suggesting that it is not what the students want to hear about but what they should want to hear about. These individuals see the reality of student issue priority and for whatever reason want to change it. For campaigns, however, this may not be about the students at all and, instead, reflect an appeal to a more implicit audience: Those people who care that the candidates care about students. Thus, while the debate is ostensibly targeted at “student” issues, it is not really focused on what concerns students

staging of the debate. They played an important role in pre-event planning, as well as helping make sure the event ran smoothly. Political communication students from my classes participated in brainstorming sessions on issues such as venue choice, audience composition, furnishings, lighting choices, debate format, timing, camera angles, etc.. Given that the debate required two days of technical planning, those students whose interest lay less in politics and more in the production elements of televised news were able to get first hand experience with a live remote broadcast. Representatives from the College Democrats and College Republicans were assigned as liaisons to each campaign. They were present as the campaigns made last minute preparations, and where able to watch the debate with the individual campaign staff in remote locations. Additionally, a number of students helped organize two very large rallies on campus prior to the debate.

Yet some might object that this form of student engagement by pointing out that it seems to be inherently more limited: it benefits students who are politically active on a more regular basis or have an interest in classes that discuss such issues. It is certainly true that the larger student body was not included in any direct way in our Senate debate when compared with other potential options such as the “student issues” model. In response to these issues, the obvious compromise would be: “why not have both.” After all, if the goal of the institution as it relates to the hosting of the debate is to maximize student engagement and enhance experiential learning outside of the classroom (and this is a big “of” of course) than should we try to maximize that student engagement at every step in the process. Students should help plan and help execute the debate, but they should also compromise the audience, influence the questions asked, and set the tone for the debate.

What is the Role of the Organizer?

This may at first seem to be the oddest and yet simplest question of them all. However, in asking it I do not mean to invoke basic time management or delegation

have articulated per se, but what those who are concerned about students (parents, for instance) believe students should be concerned about.

concerns. More specifically, I believe that we rarely if ever discuss the roles we as debate scholars, critic, and observers play when actually helping to stage such debates. Once again this is an area that everyone who has been involved with such events has, by definition, had to find the appropriate balance for. However, it is also another area that provokes a wider conversation about the role of the debate theorist in the realm of debate action.

For instance, every four years a cacophony of voices can be heard decrying the stale and stilted format of that year's presidential debates. Whether warranted or accurate, there are many who complain that the debates have become too formulaic and controlled. Whether rooted in some romantic notion of earlier popular debate, or in a prerogative to experiment with completely new forms, there is a common sense among these critics that the deliberative dialogue is not well served by the current process. I suspect that the same compliant would also be made in regard to down ballot debates if we were able to survey a large portion of their formats. Campus sponsored state and local races offer new opportunities for those of us who spend our life examining debate and argument to experiment with new forms and formats, and to adjust the expectations of what political debates necessarily have to look like. The most local races offer many new options for debate formats that break some of the traditional norms. Often this is because these races may involve more than two candidates. At the same time, these candidates are usually less personally experienced in campaigning and have a smaller campaign staff than those running for statewide office. This may mean that they are more willing to accept different proposed formats.

However, this is not exclusive to the most local of candidates. Even with more high profile state races, the debate planner has the potential to tweak and modify a whole litany of different format issues. Certainly there are constraints based on what campaigns are willing to accept. None the less, to what extent the researcher/scholar/academic uses the practice of staging electoral debates as a laboratory for observing theory (at least as it applies to format issues) put into action is a question which should hopefully generate a good deal of discussion in our community. It should be clear that by format I mean both the

model for the debate itself, as well as the setting and context in which the debate occurs. Without question one of the most often overlooked issues in hosting such debates is harmonizing the link between the two.

In the example of the 2004 CofC Senate debate, we made some adjustments to format that we believed would facilitate a good dialogue and also force the two candidates, who had both been running very “distant” campaigns on the air, to share close proximity with each other and discuss issues in a more informal discussion-centered debate. We wanted our moderator to have the ability to adapt and make judgment calls at a moment’s notice as to how to proceed and what issues to follow up on. Knowing they would be overly canned for the first debate, we wanted to challenge the candidates to address issues they may not have planned for, or to address predictable issues when framed in new ways. Our proposal was to go with what I have offhandedly labeled the “Charlie Rose” model. This model was one I appropriated from a 2002 Congressional debate in Nebraska in which I had been involved. The candidates were seated around a large oblong oval table. On one end of the oval was the moderator. The candidates sat across from each other sharing the thin central of the oval in between them. One of the cameras sat at the other end of the table from the moderator, gave us both a “one” shot of the moderator and a larger pan “three” shot of the debate. The other angles were one shots directed at each candidate.

We used a nondescript uncovered wood table that easily could have been in a kitchen or a meeting room and a set of wood low back mid-back chairs that allowed for arm resting, but which made a very low profile on camera. We had decided on a large formal room on campus that is minimally furnished as a parlor or public room from the 19th century. There was an audience of four or five individuals deep, seated in a semicircle approximately five feet behind the debaters. Overall, it was an intimate yet hardly subdued back-and-forth conversation between two candidates who, until that point, had probably never been that close to one another.

As for the debate itself, we attempted to create a model what would further our overall objective by making sure the candidates would engage each other face-to-face while

having to address a number of different issues. Unlike most debates, candidates did not give an opening statement, though they would get a short closing statement at the end of the debate¹ Instead of opening statements, we worked with the WCSC crew to put together short video packages on each of the candidates profiling who they were and what their issue priorities were going into the debate. As the program opened, we had shots of the campus lit up at night that eventually panned to Alumni Hall, where the debate occurred, and then faded into the room itself. The moderator welcomed the viewing audience, reminded everyone that this would be the first of a series of televised debates, and then he cut to these pre-planned video packages. We were able to rid ourselves of the overly canned introductory comments, while at the same time highlighting the “firstness” of the debate and providing some introduction to the issues that had been prominent.

From there the moderator briefly explained the rules and the format, and then transitioned into a series of questions directed to each candidate. One candidate would be asked a question and would have two minutes to respond. The other candidate would then receive two minutes to respond as well. At that point, the moderator could ask a follow-up question of either, or open the debate up to back and forth dialogue. This particular model worked great for what we wanted in terms of the pace of the debate and the overall tone of the event. However, we were very lucky. This model puts a heavy premium on both the intimacy of the environment and the ability of the moderator to politely rein in candidates who may wish to get the last word in all instances. Yet, on the other hand, it opens a space for a more fluid dialogue with direct back and forth debate between the two candidates facing each other across a small table. It also gave the moderator a chance to follow-up in order to clarify ambiguous statements or push the original questions in new directions. Once again, in this format the choice of a strong yet polite moderator who has a sense of timing and tone is vitally important.

¹ As a personal note, I was against both opening and closing statements, though was later convinced that the latter would make the debate more acceptable to the campaigns. Given their general disconnection to what was said in the debate, I typically have found them to be the most monotonous feature of any candidate debate in higher-profile races.

This brings us to the other major issue dealing with the influence of the debate planner: issue selection. As observers of debate as an activity, we are not only interested in tweaking the formats of the debates in order to improve on public deliberation, we might also be interested in interjecting particular topics or questions into the debate. In some instances, this is outside our realm of control entirely. Most debates have a moderator whose job it is to manage the flow of the debate. In some instances, there is a separate panel of questioners put together who ask questions independent of the moderator. Sometimes both the moderator and the panelists ask questions. There might also be a space built into the debate for questions from an audience. Most “town hall” formats rely almost exclusively on these audience questions. These questions can come directly from the audience member speaking into a microphone (whether their question has been screened or not) or submitted in advance in some written form (to be screened by the moderator).

In our case the moderator was the sole panelist. He asked all the questions and the topic areas covered were generated by a three person team consisting of the moderator, myself, and the news director at WCSC. For weeks leading up the debate we ran through major issues, picked topic areas to cover, and discussed ways to frame questions. At best we provided the moderator with a series of main areas and potential questions from each area. Some of these he would definitely cover, others he would pick from “on the fly” as the debate progressed. Our goal was to balance the journalistic need to address issues that were timely, while also interjecting topics into the debate that were not typically covered in the media.

At this point, some readers may be recoiling in disgust. The preceding paragraphs seem to endorse an overly planned, heavy-handed manipulation of the debate format subject to the whims of a few people. Yet here is where the very issue of subjective intervention comes into play. The issue is not that a handful of individuals make choices about the format and questions that will be asked, but whether someone who observes, analyses, critiques, and theorizes about debate in their professional life should use electoral debates as a testing ground to examine her ideas. It is my opinion that far too often I have seen debate organizers

defer to a local media representative to serve as moderator and or panelist in an electoral debate. For instance, a debate coach or argument instructor at a local College might spend hour of time planning a debate on campus, and then she may select a local TV personality or newspaper journalist to ask the questions of the candidates. Yet the assumption that these individuals are better suited to ask questions in the debate because they are somehow more “informed” on the issues relevant to the election rests on very shaky ground.

It should be clear that I am not at all suggesting that the presence of journalists on a debate panel is problematic on its own terms. However, I will honestly say I have sat as a debate panelist with journalists, and, for the most part, they have very specific criterion to determine what they will ask about. Putting personal interest aside, as a journalist who may also be writing a story about the debate, their question selection is guided by their professional standpoint, just as an argument scholar would also be guided. As a result, the topics they would like to see addressed are typically already those most prominent in the news cycle. In my limited experience, it is consistently the case that journalists on the panel will thereby quite reasonably strike off a question idea because they don’t think anyone will care about it, or it is far from the top of the current news agenda. Once again, this is not a call to remove journalists from electoral debate panels, but instead a question of striking an appropriate balance. Though of us who make a profession analyzing debate and argument must take a more active role not only in the presentation of debates but also in serving as, or working directly with, panelists and moderators. For those concerned about the amount of control being exerted over public discourse as a result of such activities, I might suggest that simply turning over the duties of questions to someone else, and thereby washing ones hands clean of the affair, should provide little comfort. In fact, I might suggest that it is far more irresponsible for those of us who are critical observers of such debates to simply defer to others on these matters, since such a default deferment is by no means value or impact free.¹ This is not to suggest that we all have to serve as panelists. In our instance, we worked

¹ The notable exception here is the town hall mediated debate. Yet even in this instance very few of these debates today involve unfiltered questions. Often, whether pre-screened or written in advance,

hard to strike an appropriate balance in terms of questions. The moderator (and in this instance sole panelist) was a journalist from the local television station. However, the inclusion of an argument and debate theorist on the team prepping the moderator helped to assure a more balanced range to topics and questions. The result was that we were able to provide a mix of questions, some with traditional journalistic concerns in mind: is it newsworthy, will someone care about it, has it been in the news, is it one of the top issues in the campaigns, are the candidates talking about it? At the same time, because it was a cooperative element, we were also to inject questions that didn't meet these categories: questions on topics that rarely make it to the top of the new cycles, questions about specific comments or actions by candidates that were previously un- or under-reported.

One of the great insights observers of debate and argumentation can bring to the table in such planning sessions is simply how to word the question itself. We have witnessed enough of these to know how that, in some cases, candidates for electoral office will avoid answering a question in a way that over-commits them to a position or could potentially turn off voters. In many instances, candidates rely heavily on prepared messaging strategies to deal with general topics. They will expend great mental effort to segue any question remotely on that topic back to their pre-planned points. One of the things I think many of us have become particularly attuned to is how to frame questions in ways that are neither insulting, gimmicky, or overly technical, yet at the same time leave little room for individuals to maneuver. When our moderator would say we should ask a question about topic "x," I was able to argue that every time topic "x" comes up the candidates would say roughly the same pre-planned series of point. We would then as a group try to find a new way to frame topic "x" that would maintain the importance of the topic, but also hopefully force the candidates to reveal new information, or perhaps challenge them to come up with

these questions are selected and picked by someone. Completely unfiltered town hall debates are rarely televised because of time constraints and, especially in high profile races, can create a tricky situation in getting candidates to agree. Further, for those who are strong supporters of the panelist-free, open mic format, there are substantive problems both with campaigns packing the audience as well as individual questioners dominating the topic of conversation.

answers on the spur of the moment. Our community has a great deal to bring to the process in this regard, though our involvement can also have dramatic implications.

In the instance of our debate, I suggested that we include some questions that would make the candidates a little more uncomfortable and force them to deal with the downside of their party affiliations. In the case of Tenenbaum, this would mean questions that would force her to support or condemn a range of issues. As a “South Carolina Democrat” this line of questioning challenged her to craft a very narrow, though predictable, messaging strategy. In the case of DeMint, we wanted to give him questions that would force him to address the more radically conservative elements of the South Carolina Republican Party in general, even if this meant going outside the lines of what a Senator would do while in office. I don’t think anyone who planned the debates nor did the staff of either campaign expect what came next.

In a response to a question from the moderator as to whether or not he supported a plank in the South Carolina Republican Party platform which held that “known homosexuals” should not be allowed to teach in public schools, DeMint quickly offered his support for the plank, arguing that “If a person wants to be publicly gay, they should not be teaching in the public schools.”¹ This response set off an immediate firestorm in the local press and drew stinging rebuke from Republicans and Democrats alike. Yet, much to the chagrin of some of his campaign staff, DeMint only gave more legs to the story the very next day when, in response to a questions asked by a reporter in another part of the state, DeMint offered up this analogy:” “I would have given the same answer when asked if a single woman, who was pregnant and living with her boyfriend, should be hired to teach my third grade children. I just think the moral decisions are different with a teacher.”¹

This issue burned like a wildfire for weeks as national staffers were sent to South Carolina to help DeMint “keep his mouth shut” and as DeMint made apology upon qualified apology for his comments. Yet the story had legs garnering statewide, regional and

¹ For more detailed coverage of DeMint’s response, see *The Charleston Post and Courier*, October 4, 2004, p. 1A.

international attention. DeMint's comments in the debate became a focal point of questioning from Tim Russert when both candidates appeared on his show prior to the election. In the end, most observers of South Carolina politics seem to be conflicted about the impact on the campaign. In the larger sense, most agree that Tenenbaum, for other reasons, would have lost in the long run anyway. However, whether or not this particular issue impacted DeMint and in what way is unclear. I might argue that there are much longer term implications for the Republicans in South Carolina, but this will have to wait until another time.

While it might seem almost fantastic to imagine, we might then begin to ask questions about the "ethical" implications of our involvement in such debates. Regardless of what some may argue, recent events should bear witness to the fact that the outcome of electoral campaigns can have a substantial impact on the lives of millions. Furthermore, the results of individual races are not always predetermined, and, at least in the more high profile races, individual question choice can play a big role in the events that unfold during a debate. This brings us back to the 2004 Senate debate. In the end, I felt that the inclusion of the now infamous "gay teachers" question (though technically not something that may come on a Senator's plate anytime soon) was justified because, when compared with the typical stock set of issues they would confront, it caught the candidate off guard, forced him to depart from his pre-planned answers, and gave the audience some insight into the authentic or political nature of DeMint's social outlook. To me this is a classic example of how debate and argument scholars can bring to the table questions and topics that a journalist may not. Again, this is no fault of professional journalists, only a reflection of different demands.

However, it did give me pause to reflect on what guides our choices in these moments. What do we do about those instances in which we advocate for adjustment to both content and format of electoral debates out of a need to "experiment" with different models? While the term experiment may be an unfairly loaded one, there might come a point in which a debate organizer or panelist chooses to insert something in the debate for

¹ For various reports of these later comments see The AP State and Local Wire, October 5, 2004.

their own professional reasons, and this change can have enormous impacts for “real world” elections. I am not sure how we would go about discussing this issue. I would only suggest that as we encourage each other to become more active in electoral debates we maintain a healthy dialogue about what obligations we may or may not have to the audiences watching.

Winding Down: Reflecting on the Future

While our experience in the campaign of 2004 is not in any way more spectacular or notable than what many in our community have done for years, I hope this short narrative has, in its most minimal sense, raised questions and highlighted pitfalls for individuals planning such events in the future. More to the broader point, I would hope it could serve as an example about how we can begin a dialogue bridging theory and practice as it relates to electoral debate performance. Encompassed in the daily activities of practice that is in the practice of setting up of debates there are numerous areas in which community dialogue and information sharing would be extremely beneficial.

Beyond simply starting a dialogue about how we plan these debates, I would suggest a concerted effort to catalog and archive these “down ballot” debates in some organized manner. I have had to rely on, against my better judgment, anecdotal examples throughout this work, yet new advances in information technologies and data storage are making it more and more possible to collect, store, and code debates just as some of us already do with campaign ads or individual speeches. In the end, the need to balance our analytical focus will necessitate such an archiving effort on the part of those of us who spend our days studying political debates, and the cooperation of those who also spend their evenings planning such debates will be vital in getting this project off the ground.

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